

Immigration and Urbanization**Lesson 3**

Politics in the Gilded Age

Key Terms and People

political machine A group that controlled a political party

graft Illegal use of political influence for personal gain

Boss Tweed Head of New York City's powerful Democratic political machine

patronage The giving of government jobs to people who had helped a candidate get elected

civil service Government administration

Rutherford B. Hayes 19th president of the United States

James A. Garfield 20th president of the United States

Chester A. Arthur 21st president of the United States

Pendleton Civil Service Act Act that implemented merit system in civil service hiring

Grover Cleveland 22nd and 24th president of the United States

Benjamin Harrison 23rd president of the United States

Before You Read

In the last lesson you read about problems that existed in America's growing cities. In this lesson you will read about the people and organizations that controlled the nation's major cities and how reformers tried to end corruption.

As You Read

Add details to a timeline featuring the people and events of the Gilded Age.

**THE EMERGENCE OF
POLITICAL MACHINES**

How did political machines control the cities?

During the late 1800s a **political machine** ran many cities. This group controlled the activities of a city's political party and was headed by a boss. It offered services to businesses and voters in exchange for political or financial support.

The boss controlled city government and jobs in the police, fire, and sanitation departments. The boss controlled agencies that granted licenses to businesses and funded construction projects. Bosses won loyalty and influence because of the control they had and for solving problems. Many bosses were immigrants, too. They spoke to immigrants in their own language and helped them find jobs

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and housing. In return, immigrants pledged their votes.

1. Name two ways in which political machines held power.

MUNICIPAL GRAFT AND SCANDAL**How were political bosses corrupt?**

Political machines provided cities with vital services. But many bosses became corrupt and became rich through **graft**, or the illegal use of political influence for personal gain. To win elections, party members used fake names to cast enough votes to win.

Another illegal practice was the kickback. Workers on city construction projects would charge a higher price for their services and then “kick back” part of the fee to the bosses, who were also taking bribes from businesses in return for allowing illegal or unsafe activities.

William M. Tweed, known as **Boss Tweed**, was a powerful political boss. He became the head of Tammany Hall, New York City’s most powerful Democratic political machine, and ran the Tweed Ring, a group of corrupt politicians.

Thomas Nast, a political cartoonist, made fun of Tweed in newspapers. Eventually, the public grew outraged by Tweed’s corrupt practices. Authorities broke up the Tweed Ring in 1871. He was sentenced to prison.

2. Name two forms of corruption practiced by political bosses.

CIVIL SERVICE REPLACES PATRONAGE**How was civil service reformed?**

For many decades, presidents had complained about the problem of **patronage**. This is the giving of government jobs to people of the same party who had helped a candidate get elected. As a result, many unqualified and corrupt workers were hired.

Reformers wanted to end patronage and begin a merit system. Jobs in **civil service**, or government administration, would go to the most qualified people, regardless of their political views.

President **Rutherford B. Hayes** attempted to reform civil service. He named independents to his cabinet and set up a commission to investigate customhouses, centers of patronage. Then he fired two top officials of the New York customhouse. When some members of the Republican Party objected, Hayes decided not to run for reelection in 1880.

The party quickly divided over the issue of patronage hiring. The Stalwarts opposed changes in the patronage system. The reformers supported changing the system. The party eventually settled on an independent candidate, **James A. Garfield**, who won the presidential election but turned out to have ties to the reformers. Shortly after being elected, he was assassinated by a Stalwart.

Garfield’s vice-president, Chester A. Arthur, succeeded him. Despite being a Stalwart, Arthur turned reformer when he became president. He pushed through a civil service reform bill known as the **Pendleton Civil Service Act** of 1883. This act created a bipartisan civil service commission to give government jobs based on merit, not politics. It helped reform the civil service.

Lesson 3, continued

Meanwhile, in state government, some governors were attempting to make reforms as well. For example, New York's governor, Theodore Roosevelt, refused to fill civil service jobs through patronage. He ignored the state Republican machine's wishes relating to policy, which upset the Republican Party. The machine leaders sought to remove him by having Roosevelt nominated to replace the vice-president who had died in office. Roosevelt accepted the nomination, and New York's politics were back in the machine's control.

3. What was the purpose of the bipartisan civil service commission?
- _____
- _____

BUSINESS BUYS INFLUENCE**What happened to tariffs?**

The Pendleton Civil Service Act had mixed results. More qualified workers did fill government positions. But because politicians had no jobs to offer, they had trouble seeking money from supporters. As a result, some politicians turned to wealthy leaders for financial support. This strengthened the ties between government and business.

Political reformers in the late 1800s also addressed the issue of tariffs. A tariff is a tax placed on goods coming

into or going out of a country. Big business favored keeping or raising tariffs because they protected U.S. industry from foreign competition. The Democratic Party did not want high tariffs since they led to higher prices.

Tariffs were a key issue in presidential elections for years. In 1884 **Grover Cleveland**, a Democrat, won the presidency. He tried but failed to reduce tariffs because he had no congressional support. In 1890 Cleveland ran against Republican **Benjamin Harrison**, who was supported by big business. While Cleveland won more popular votes than Harrison, Harrison took a majority of electoral votes. He signed the McKinley Tariff Act into law, raising tariffs to their highest level ever. Then, in 1892 Cleveland defeated Harrison and became the only president to serve two nonconsecutive terms. He wanted to lower tariffs, but would not sign a bill that provided for a federal income tax. Nevertheless, Congress passed the Wilson-Gorman Tariff without Cleveland's signature, so tariffs were lowered.

In 1897 William McKinley became president. He raised tariffs again.

4. Which two presidents raised tariffs?
- _____
- _____

Lesson 3, continued

Fill in the chart below by writing answers to questions about the Gilded Age.

1876	Rutherford B. Hayes elected president	→	1. What was Hayes's position on civil service reform? What did he do to promote it?
1880	James A. Garfield elected president	→	2. In the debate over civil service reform, did Garfield seem to favor the Stalwarts or the reformers?
1881	Garfield assassinated; Chester A. Arthur assumes the presidency	→	3. What position did Arthur take on civil service reform, and what did he do to support it?
1883	Pendleton Civil Service Act passed	→	4. What did the Pendleton Civil Service Act do?
1884	Grover Cleveland elected president	→	5. What was Cleveland's position on tariffs, and what did he do to promote this position?
1888	Benjamin Harrison elected president	→	6. What was Harrison's position on tariffs, and what did he do to support that stand?
1892	Cleveland reelected president	→	7. What happened to tariffs during Cleveland's second presidency?
1897	William McKinley elected president	→	8. What happened to tariffs during McKinley's presidency?